

THE TERRIBLE TRAGEDY NEAR LONDON.

THE PRISONER BEFORE THE MAGISTRATES.

At Stratford (Essex), yesterday, William Gouldstone, aged 26, blacksmith, Walthamstow, was charged with murdering, on Wednesday night, three of his children, aged respectively 3½, 2½, and 16 months, by drowning; and, further, with murdering his two infants, aged seven days each, by striking them on the head with a hammer. The prisoner folded his hands together on being placed in the dock, and rested his head on his hands. He seemed careworn and restless, looking continually about the court. The first witness was Mrs. Hamilton, a monthly nurse, who had been attending the prisoner's wife during her confinement of twins, and who had previously for nine weeks lodged in the prisoner's house. She deposed that about five o'clock on Wednesday evening the prisoner came home, and his wife remarked that he was unusually early. Witness left the bedroom in order that the husband and wife might converse, and shortly afterwards she heard screams of murder from the latter. She ran in and heard Mrs. Gouldstone exclaim, "Good God, he is murdering my children." Witness was unable to open the door of the bedroom, and cried for help, which soon came, and the prisoner opened the door. Witness said, "Oh, you wicked man, what have you done?" He said, "I have killed my children; I am a happy man now," and he added, addressing his wife, "the other three children are in the cistern." Witness saw the twins were bleeding and apparently dying, and afterwards followed the prisoner into the kitchen, where she met him coming from the kitchen with the youngest of the first three children in his arms, apparently dead. She was so horrified she ran back to the bedroom and stayed ten minutes. When she returned she found the three elder children in a row on the floor, all dead from drowning. One twin died at once and the second yesterday. Prisoner said when arrested he knew he should be hanged. He was remanded.

The "Press Association" says the murder continues to create profound sensation in the quiet neighbourhood of Walthamstow, and during the day hundreds have visited the scene of the tragedy. Gouldstone and his wife and family resided in one of about a dozen modern cottages erected by the side of the Great Eastern railway, and they occupied the two back rooms on the first floor. Here they have lived for the last ten months, and were regarded as very quiet people by the neighbour. They have never been heard to quarrel, and prisoner seems to have gone very regularly to his employment as a blacksmith. He was seldom seen in a public house unless to fetch the supper beer for himself and wife. Every one seemed to regard him as a very steady man, and he did not appear desirous of making many personal friends. It is stated that until the birth of the twins last week he appeared to take an interest in the other children, who had great affection for him, and were delighted with his attention, whilst his wife was passionately fond of them. After the birth of twins the prisoner appeared to be somewhat depressed, and to have spoken very little to his wife or any one else, although little notice was taken of this, and nothing occurred to betoken insanity or even to excite suspicion that his mind was in the least degree unhinged. Since his incarceration he has made no further statement, and has preserved on the whole a calm demeanour. The three children who were drowned in the cistern present no outward signs of violence, and look more as if they were in a happy slumber than in the arms of death. The weapon with which the twins, who were at their mother's breast at the time, were murdered, was an ordinary carpenter's hammer. One of them exhibits no bruise, but the skull is battered and softened, and this was the first to succumb. The other was much bruised about the forehead, and lived for some hours, although it bled freely from the wounds and also from the nose. The prisoner's wife did not at first appear to realise the awful nature of the tragedy, but when the shocking circumstances of the case dawned upon her in her weak condition, she was inconsolable, and throughout yesterday was in a very critical state. Those who are attending her are unremitting in their efforts, and do not disguise the dangerous condition she is in. It seems that her father and mother are both dead, and she has no near relatives whatever. Much commiseration is therefore felt for her in her terrible situation.